

personhood, including our spending, there are a few key steps I have found helpful in actually walking this out.

The first is to **create space**. We need to incorporate opportunities for pause if we want to have any level of insight into ourselves and the world around us. This could mean scheduling reflection times each night before bed, or it could look like creating margins within our day to process experiences as they happen. No matter the time of day or whether we write it down or simply think about it, intentionality and daily practice are necessary until this becomes a highly integrated part of our thought processes and how we move through our days.

Once we've created space, we need to **observe objectively**. This part entails some of that "scientific method" we all learned in fifth grade. Observe yourself as if you are a biologist in the wild looking on at some unknown creature, doing your best not to disturb it. We don't have judgments for this creature, there's no condemnation for what they're eating or how they're interacting with their species because all of it is information that will be useful to understanding how they operate. We are simply gathering data. We often avoid examining ourselves because we are our own worst critics. But it's not until we look at our actions without criticism that we are able to move on to the next step.

Inquiring inquisitively (can you tell we like alliteration?): This is the part where we ask questions. These questions come after our acceptance of objectivity and should be approached with care and kindness toward ourselves. We can ask:

What is happening in the environment around me?

How am I feeling?

What am I thinking?

How do I want to respond? What do I think that says about me?

What feels most important at this juncture?

What do my perceived "failures" tell me about myself?

These are some big questions. The type that can really help us see and accept more of ourselves and inform the steps we want to take with our spending. They are meant to engage us in a true discovery process.

You'll notice that none of them begin with "why." That's on purpose. It's not that "why" is a bad word, but often when it comes to curiosity, beginning with "why" can put us on the defense. It has a pretentious, condescending tone that can immediately cause our walls to go up, as we